From Quantum Measurement to Gravity

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Abstract

We propose that gravity can be understood as the physical backreaction of quantum measurement. Standard results, horizon scales, entropy bounds, and the Bekenstein–Hawking area law, follow from Landauer's principle at the Unruh temperature as consequences of Newton's laws of motion and gravitation. To ground our idea, we extend a specific example from our previous work, a bilocal microstate construction where entangled photon pairs emitted from a localized source, propagate into opposite Rindler wedges. We show how polarisation measurements produce discrete energy-momentum impulses and correlated classical bits. Each such microstate is described geometrically at the horizon by an Aichelburg–Sexl pp-wave solution, whose longitudinal shift generates spatial separation between the wedges and whose transverse focusing increments the horizon area. The framework provides an operational realisation of ER=EPR at the level of these individual microstates, and complements the thermodynamic approaches of Jacobson and Verlinde by supplying a microphysical process underlying each entropy increment.

1 Introduction

Two landmark results establish that gravity and Unurh thermodynamics are deeply intertwined. Jacobson showed that the Einstein equations can be derived from thermodynamic identities applied to local Rindler horizons, with horizon entropy playing the role of the fundamental quantity from which spacetime dynamics emerge [1]. Verlinde extended this perspective, arguing that gravitational forces arise from entropy gradients on holographic screens, recasting gravity as an entropic rather than a fundamental interaction [2]. Both frameworks, however, operate at the level of bulk thermodynamics and leave open a prior question: what physical process underlies each individual entropy increment?

We argue that the answer is quantum measurement. Each act of information acquisition by a physical observer constitutes a discrete microstate event, and the collective backreaction of such events, together with the causal correlations they induce, gives rise to gravitational effects. The argument proceeds in three steps. First, any observation is mediated by a physical interaction: information transfer necessarily involves an exchange of energy and momentum between the observed system and the detector, a discrete impulse. Second, by the equivalence principle, this impulse is locally indistinguishable from the effect of a gravitational field: no local measurement can distinguish the recoil associated with a quantum measurement event from acceleration in a gravitational potential. Third, when such impulses are modelled geometrically, via Aichelburg–Sexl (AS) pp-wave solutions, as we explore, they imprint energy and information directly onto horizon geometry, and coarse-graining over the resulting ensemble recovers standard horizon thermodynamics. A unifying structure runs through the relations, and it is worth pausing to discuss the general ideas involved before diving into our explicit example.

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1.1 Conceptual Roadmap and Subjective Relations

In each case in our argument, the relation between two adjacent concepts has the same logical character: every instance of the more abstract concept is grounded in an instance of the more physical one, but not every instance of the more physical concept gives rise to the more abstract one *for a given observer*. The gap in each case is filled by subjectivity. Quantum state reduction is always backed by an observation, it is a Bayesian update on the observer's part, but an observation that carries no new information for that observer produces no state reduction. Equally, every observation is backed by an energy-momentum transfer, but not every such transfer constitutes an observation for you: an interaction involving a different "observer" leaves your knowledge unchanged. The Unruh effect suggests the same structure extends to the equivalence principle: an accelerating observer perceives a thermal bath and attributes it to a gravitational field, while an inertial observer sees only vacuum. Whether an acceleration counts as gravity is perspectival in precisely the same sense. In each case the relation is an identification, not a causal link, and the identification is observer-relative.

This stands in sharp contrast to the Diósi–Penrose objective collapse programme [3, 4], which postulates that gravity *causes* quantum state reduction as an objective, observer-independent physical process. Figure 1 summarises this contrast. The three solid arrows represent the perspectival grounding relations described above; the single dashed arrow represents the Diósi–Penrose causal postulate. It is the only relation in the diagram claimed to be objective and observer-independent, and it is the only one we do not adopt.

$$\begin{tikzcd}
\text{Gravitational field} \arrow[r, dashed, "\text{Diósi–Penrose}"] & \text{Quantum state reduction} \\
\text{Acceleration} \arrow[u, "\text{equivalence principle}"] \arrow[r, "\text{energy–momentum transfer}"'] & \text{Observation} \arrow[u, "\text{Bayesian update}"']
\end{tikzcd}$$

Figure 1: Solid arrows denote "substrate" relations: $A \to B$ means every instance of B is physically realised by an instance of A, for a given observer. The dashed arrow denotes the Diósi–Penrose postulate, where the relation is claimed to hold objectively rather than observer-relatively.

To make this concrete, we build on the microstate construction of [5], in which bilocal driving sources generate entangled Rindler excitations that realise individual terms of the Unruh thermal ensemble. The present paper applies and extends that construction. Entangled pairs emitted from a localised source propagate into left and right Rindler wedges; polarisation measurement events produce discrete energy-momentum impulses and correlated classical bits. We show that each such microstate carries a calculable gravitational imprint, modelled by an AS pp-wave solution, and that coarse-graining over the ensemble recovers standard horizon thermodynamics. This construction also provides an operational realisation of ER=EPR at the level of individual microstates: entanglement is converted into geometric information, and each measurement event contributes a discrete, calculable increment to horizon entropy.

1.2 Relation to existing Literature

The idea that spacetime geometry is connected to quantum information has been developed along several distinct lines, none of which supplies the microstate-level operational

picture we develop here. Jacobson's derivation of the Einstein equations from horizon thermodynamics [1] and Verlinde's entropic gravity programme [2] both operate at the level of bulk thermodynamic averages, leaving open the question of what physical process underlies each individual entropy increment. Van Raamsdonk [6] argued that entanglement between boundary degrees of freedom is what holds bulk geometry together, and that reducing entanglement tears spacetime apart, a result that motivates our identification of the ER=EPR bridge with correlated measurement events, though his framework operates with thermal boundary states rather than individual non-thermal microstates. Susskind and Maldacena's ER=EPR correspondence [7] identifies entangled pairs with Einstein–Rosen bridges at the level of bulk thermodynamics; we realise this correspondence operationally at the level of a single microstate, with a calculable geometric imprint sourced by a specific bilocal emission event.

The closest antecedent to our geometric construction is the gravitational shockwave programme of Dray and 't Hooft [8] and 't Hooft's subsequent S-matrix approach to black hole scattering [**?**]. solutions sourced by infalling classical or semiclassical particles to define scattering amplitudes at the horizon, and the longitudinal position shift of the AS wave is the fundamental horizon degree of freedom in their picture, in precise agreement with our geometric construction. The key difference is that 't Hooft's sources are classical infalling particles rather than quantum entangled pairs emitted from a common ancestor in the past, and the measurement and information acquisition framing is absent from his construction. Our bilocal source selects individual non-thermal microstates from the Unruh ensemble, giving each AS imprint a definite quantum origin and connecting the geometric shift directly to a classical bit acquired by an observer.

Microstate counting for black holes has been approached from several directions. Strominger and Vafa [9] achieved exact entropy counting for extremal black holes using D-brane configurations in string theory, establishing that black hole entropy has a microscopic origin, but the microstates are defined algebraically in a high-energy string framework far removed from the operational measurement picture developed here. Carlip [**?**] derived black hole entropy from the Virasoro algebra of diffeomorphisms at the horizon boundary, identifying microstates with boundary excitations; our AS pp-wave imprints may provide a physical realisation of these boundary excitations in terms of measurement events, a connection we leave for future work. Bianchi's loop quantum gravity microstate counting [**?**] assigns discrete area increments to individual spin network punctures at the horizon, structurally analogous to our result that each measurement event contributes a discrete AS-wave area increment; the difference is that our punctures have a definite dynamical origin in a quantum measurement event rather than a kinematical definition in the LQG Hilbert space.

Interior reconstruction via the Papadodimas–Raju programme [**?**] addresses how degrees of freedom behind the horizon are encoded in exterior operators, a question closely related to our spatial bit argument in Section 4.1. Their framework requires thermality of the boundary state, whereas our construction works microstate by microstate with a non-thermal source; it would be interesting to determine whether our classical spatial record, the anticorrelated helicity bits registered by Wright and Lester, realises the interior reconstruction map at the single-microstate level, but we leave this comparison for future work.

What distinguishes the present construction from all of these approaches is the combination of three features that do not appear together elsewhere in the literature: a non-thermal bilocal source that selects individual microstates from the Unruh ensemble rather than assuming thermality as a primitive; the identification of each microstate with a specific quantum measurement event carrying a calculable energy-momentum transfer; and an operational realisation of ER=EPR at the single-microstate level with a concrete geometric imprint. Each of these features appears in isolation in various forms across the literature, but their combination, and in particular the grounding of horizon geometry in

individual measurement events rather than bulk thermodynamic averages, appears to be new.

2 Motivating Heuristics

Landauer's principle associates a minimal energy cost with the acquisition of information [10]. For an accelerated observer, the relevant temperature is the Unruh temperature [11]. Substituting one into the other eliminates temperature entirely, yielding a relation between information acquisition, energy transfer, and acceleration (a version of the BHT first law, equation (3)). This is not merely an algebraic convenience: it is a concrete dictionary between the thermal description natural to a Rindler observer and the non-thermal global Minkowski description, with the apparent thermality of the vacuum emerging as a consequence of the observer's acceleration rather than as a fundamental property of the state. In this way we derive a sequence of standard results in black hole thermodynamics as a consequence of Newton's laws.

2.1 The Unruh-Landauer Relation

Landauer's principle suggests that the acquisition of ΔH bits of information by a physical observer requires a minimum energy transfer

$$\Delta E \geq k_B \ln(2)\, T\, \Delta H. \tag{1}$$

We note that Landauer's principle is conventionally stated for information erasure rather than acquisition. Here we apply it to acquisition, which is the physically relevant process for an observer registering a measurement outcome. The bound has the same form in both cases; we apply it to acquisition on the grounds that registering a measurement outcome is physically equivalent to a bit being written into the detector's state, which is the process Landauer's principle governs.

For an observer undergoing proper acceleration a, the Unruh effect associates a temperature

$$T = \frac{\hbar a}{2\pi k_B c} \tag{2}$$

with the local vacuum. Substituting into Landauer's bound eliminates $k_B T$, yielding

$$\boxed{\Delta E \geq \frac{\hbar a \ln(2)}{2\pi c}\, \Delta H.} \tag{3}$$

Temperature has dropped out entirely: equation (3) is a temperature-independent relation between energy, acceleration, and information, suitable for the Minkowski vacuum. In what follows, standard results emerge as consequences of this single relation and Newton's laws.

2.2 Momentum Transfer and Acceleration

The energy transfer ΔE implied by equation (3) is carried by a physical quantum — matter or radiation — mediating the measurement interaction. We refer to this as the *thrust quantum* of effective mass m_t. (This will actually be a pure energy carrier in our later microstate example.) For a relativistic carrier, the associated momentum transfer is

$$\Delta p = \frac{\Delta E}{c}. \tag{4}$$

We take the interaction time to be the order of the light-crossing time across the interaction region, $\Delta t \sim 2r/c$, corresponding to a causal exchange over the scale r. The

numerical factor of 2 is not fixed a priori at this level; it will be determined by requiring consistency with the gravitational scale that emerges below. For a detector of mass m_d, Newton's second law in impulse form gives

$$a = \frac{\Delta p}{m_d \Delta t} = \frac{\Delta E}{2 m_d r}. \tag{5}$$

2.3 The Schwarzschild Radius

We match the acceleration inferred from the measurement-induced impulse to the Newtonian gravitational field in order to identify the characteristic length scale associated with the detector. The thrust quantum carries energy ΔE and produces an acceleration a on the detector. Identifying this with the Newtonian gravitational acceleration due to the mass m_t at distance r.

$$a = \frac{G m_t}{r^2}, \tag{6}$$

and substituting equation (5) with $\Delta E = m_t c^2$, we obtain

$$\frac{m_t c^2}{2 m_d r} = \frac{G m_t}{r^2}. \tag{7}$$

Solving for r:

$$r = \frac{2 G m_d}{c^2} \equiv r_s, \tag{8}$$

which is precisely the Schwarzschild radius of the detector mass m_d. This fixes the factor of 2 in the interaction time retroactively: the choice $\Delta r = 2r/c$ is the unique one consistent with Newtonian gravity and the correct Schwarzschild scale.

It is notable that the resulting length scale is set by the detector mass m_d, rather than the source mass m_t. This reflects the fact that the construction is inherently observer-centred: the acceleration entering the argument is the response of the detector to the measurement-induced impulse, and the associated scale is therefore the horizon radius relevant to that observer. In this sense, the quantity r_s should be interpreted not as the Schwarzschild radius of the source, but as the characteristic horizon scale associated with the detector as a physical system undergoing measurement. This is consistent with the observer-dependence of horizon structure in relativistic settings, as exemplified by the Unruh effect, where acceleration alone gives rise to a causal horizon.

2.4 Surface Gravity

Evaluating the acceleration at $r = r_s$ gives the surface gravity of the detector:

$$\kappa = \frac{G m_d}{r_s^2} = \frac{c^4}{4 G m_d}, \tag{9}$$

in agreement with the standard Schwarzschild result. This is the acceleration that appears in the Unruh temperature associated with the detector's horizon, $T = \hbar\kappa / 2\pi k_B c$, providing an internal consistency check on the framework.

2.5 Bekenstein-Hawking Entropy

Returning to the Unruh-Landauer relation (3) and substituting the surface gravity κ for a, the entropy increment associated with an energy increment $\Delta E = c^2 \Delta m_d$ is

$$\ln(2) \Delta H \leq \frac{2\pi c}{\hbar \kappa} \Delta E = \frac{8\pi G m_d}{\hbar c^3} \cdot c^2 \Delta m_d. \tag{10}$$

Expressing this in terms of the change in Schwarzschild area $\Delta A = 32\pi G^2 m_d \Delta m_d / c^4$:

$$\ln(2)\Delta H \leq \frac{\Delta A}{4\ell_P^2}, \qquad \ell_P^2 = \frac{\hbar G}{c^3}, \tag{11}$$

which is the Bekenstein-Hawking area law. Each measurement event contributes a discrete entropy increment proportional to the area imprinted on the horizon by the associated energy-momentum transfer.

The two bounds are saturated simultaneously when $a = c^2/R$ — which is exactly the condition for being *at a horizon*. The horizon is therefore not just where thermodynamics happens to work out, it is the unique locus where the minimum cost of information acquisition equals the maximum information content of the region.

2.6 Summary

Beginning from the single relation (3), and using only Newton's laws and the equivalence principle, we have recovered the Schwarzschild radius, the surface gravity, and the Bekenstein-Hawking area law as consequences of the observation $\rightarrow$ acceleration identification. These are standard results, but their derivation here from the physical cost of information acquisition rather than from thermodynamic postulates is the point.

The thrust quantum introduced in this section, the physical carrier of the measurement-induced impulse, will be given a explicit microstate realization in the sections that follow. It is identified with one of a pair of entangled photons modeled as Aichelburg-Sexl pp-waves crossing past Rindler horizons in the Unruh picture. In this case the back reaction of a single force carrier in one wedge is correlated with an equal and opposite reaction in the other from a common source.

3 Bilocal Microstate Construction

Let $\hbar = c = 1$.

The heuristic arguments of Section 2 establish a relationship between information acquisition, acceleration, and gravitational effects, but leave open the question of what a single microstate looks like concretely. In standard treatments, the Unruh effect is derived by coupling a detector to a pre-existing acceleration and reading off a thermal response from the vacuum. Following [5], we invert this logic: we place an interaction in the past, where a source injects non-thermal entangled excitations into the field, and show that the observer's accelerated response is driven by these source-induced excitations. The thermal ensemble then emerges as a coarse-grained aggregate of such microstates, rather than being a primitive property of the vacuum.

We now upgrade this construction from a spin-0 scalar field in the original source [5] to the spin-1 electromagnetic field. This is not merely a technical generalisation. As we show, the photon carries a unit of action $\hbar$ per cycle alongside its energy $E = \hbar\omega$, which closes the Landauer gap left open in Section 2: in each wedge, the minimum actionable event in the construction is precisely a single photon, and its polarisation state constitutes the classical bit acquired by each observer. The anticorrelated helicities of the entangled pair are the natural completion of the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ swap symmetry between wedges, and as we discuss in Section 5, they imprint a definite geometric signature onto the horizon consistent with the ER=EPR identification.

3.1 The Paz–Lester–Wright Setup

We retain the Alice-and-Bob style naming convention. Three observers are placed at spacetime positions $(t, z) = (0, 1)$, $(0, -1)$, and $(-1, 0)$, named *Wright* (R), *Lester* (L),

and *Paz* (P) respectively, a mnemonic for Right, Left, and Past. Paz serves as the common causal ancestor of Wright and Lester (see Figure 2).

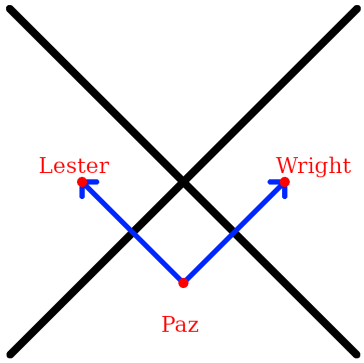

Figure 2: A source in the past, Paz (P), emits an entangled photon pair that accelerates Wright (R) into the right Rindler wedge and Lester (L) into the left Rindler wedge. The two null directions of propagation define the x^+ and x^- axes of the double-null coordinate system.

Paz emits an entangled pair of spin-1 massless photons with momenta $\pm k$ and Rindler frequency $\omega = \omega_k$. The momenta are perfectly balanced, so the source exhibits no net back-reaction in this minimal model. The two photons propagate into the left and right Rindler wedges, where Lester and Wright detect them respectively, each registering a helicity eigenvalue and acquiring one classical bit of information.

3.2 Double-Null Gauge

The emission event naturally defines two null directions: the right-moving photon has wave-vector k_R^μ and the left-moving photon has wave-vector $k_L^\mu = -k_R^\mu$. These two null directions are precisely the x^+ and x^- axes of double-null coordinates

$$x^\pm = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(t \pm z), \tag{12}$$

with transverse coordinates $\mathbf{x}_\perp = (x^1, x^2)$. Working in this frame we impose the symmetric double-null gauge condition

$$A_+(x) = 0, \qquad A_-(x) = 0, \tag{13}$$

so that the gauge field is supported entirely on the transverse components $\mathbf{A}_\perp = (A^1, A^2)$. This gauge respects the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ symmetry that swaps the two wedges ($x^+ \leftrightarrow x^-$) simultaneously with ($R \leftrightarrow L$), and therefore treats both observers symmetrically by construction. The residual gauge freedom is fixed by requiring $\partial_i A^i = 0$ in the transverse plane, leaving precisely the two physical helicity degrees of freedom $\epsilon^i_{(\lambda)}$ with $\lambda = \pm 1$.

The lack of manifest four-dimensional covariance in equation (13) is a consequence of aligning the gauge with the pair of physical null directions selected by the source, rather than an arbitrary choice. The full Lorentz group is broken to the little group preserving the pair $\{k_R^\mu, k_L^\mu\}$, which is the two-dimensional Euclidean group $ISO(2)$ acting on the transverse plane. This is precisely the little group of massless particles, and the two helicity eigenstates $\lambda = \pm 1$ are its irreducible representations. All physical results are independent of the gauge choice.

3.3 The Bilocal Source

In double-null gauge the electromagnetic field is characterised by its transverse components alone. The bilocal driving source generalises the scalar construction to

$$J^{ij}(x,y) = \lambda\, \epsilon^{i*}_{(-1)}\, \epsilon^{j}_{(+1)}\, f_L(x)\, f_R(y), \tag{14}$$

where λ is a coupling constant, f_L and f_R are normalised mode profiles supported on the left and right wedges respectively, and $\epsilon^i_{(\lambda)}$ are the circular polarisation vectors

$$\epsilon^i_{(+1)} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix}1\\ i\end{pmatrix}, \qquad \epsilon^i_{(-1)} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix}1\\ -i\end{pmatrix}. \tag{15}$$

The index structure of (14) assigns helicity $+1$ to the right-moving mode and helicity -1 to the left-moving mode: the pair is *anticorrelated* in helicity. This is the unique assignment consistent with angular momentum conservation at the emission vertex and with the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ wedge-swap symmetry, under which $\epsilon^i_{(+1)} \leftrightarrow \epsilon^i_{(-1)}$.

The sourced Lagrangian reads

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L}_{\text{sourced}} &= \mathcal{L}_{\text{free}} + \tfrac{1}{2}\lambda \int J^{ij}(x,y)\; A^+_i(x)\, A^+_j(y)\; d^4x\, d^4y \;+\; \text{h.c.}\\ &= \mathcal{L}_{\text{free}} + \tfrac{1}{2}\lambda\Big(a^{L\dagger}_{-k,(-1)}\, a^{R\dagger}_{k,(+1)} \;+\; a^{L}_{-k,(-1)}\, a^{R}_{k,(+1)}\Big),\end{aligned} \tag{16}$$

where $a^{L\dagger}_{-k,(-1)}$ and $a^{R\dagger}_{k,(+1)}$ are creation operators for left-wedge helicity -1 and right-wedge helicity $+1$ modes respectively. The interaction term in (16) is a two-mode squeezing interaction at frequency ω, now resolved by helicity: it is the direct vector-field analogue of the scalar squeezing interaction [12], with the anticorrelated polarisation structure made explicit. The photon pair carries total angular momentum zero, consistent with emission from a scalar source at Paz.

Each photon carries energy $E = \hbar\omega$ and, as a mode of the electromagnetic field, constitutes precisely one quantum of action $\hbar$ per oscillation cycle. The thrust quantum of Section 2 is thereby identified with a single photon: the minimum actionable event is the emission and detection of one such quantum. The energy transferred per bit acquired is $\Delta E = \hbar\omega$, saturating the Unruh–Landauer bound (3) at the fundamental quantum level. This closes the Landauer gap: registering a photon's helicity writes one classical bit into the detector's physical state, which is precisely the process Landauer's principle governs.

3.4 Polarisation Bogoliubov Transformation

We now show that the polarisation labels survive the Rindler–Unruh mode decomposition, so that the thermal ensemble retains its helicity structure and the anticorrelation of the emitted pair descends unambiguously to the level of individual Rindler microstates.

In the transverse plane, the electromagnetic field in double-null gauge decomposes into two independent scalar-like sectors labelled by helicity $\lambda = \pm 1$. For each sector, the right-wedge field expands as

$$A^i_\lambda(x) = \int_0^\infty \frac{d\Omega}{2\pi}\, \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\Omega}}\, \epsilon^i_{(\lambda)} \left[b^R_{\Omega,\lambda}\, u^R_\Omega(x) + b^{R\dagger}_{\Omega,\lambda}\, u^{R*}_\Omega(x)\right], \tag{17}$$

where $u^R_\Omega(x)$ are the right-wedge Rindler modes at Rindler frequency Ω, and $b^R_{\Omega,\lambda}$, $b^{R\dagger}_{\Omega,\lambda}$ are the corresponding annihilation and creation operators satisfying

$$\left[b^R_{\Omega,\lambda},\, b^{R\dagger}_{\Omega',\lambda'}\right] = \delta(\Omega - \Omega')\, \delta_{\lambda\lambda'}. \tag{18}$$

An identical expansion holds in the left wedge with $R \to L$ and $\lambda \to -\lambda$, reflecting the anticorrelated helicity assignment. Because each helicity sector is independently a scalar-like sector, the Bogoliubov transformation relating Minkowski and Rindler modes takes the same form in each sector. For helicity λ at Rindler frequency Ω, the Unruh modes are

$$c_{\Omega,\lambda} = \cosh\theta_\Omega \, b^R_{\Omega,\lambda} - \sinh\theta_\Omega \, b^{L\dagger}_{\Omega,-\lambda}, \tag{19}$$

where $\tanh\theta_\Omega = e^{-\pi\Omega c/a}$ encodes the Unruh distribution at acceleration a, and $-\lambda$ on the left-wedge operator reflects the anticorrelation. The transformation (19) is the standard Bogoliubov relation for a massless field [11, 13], now carrying a helicity label throughout. The Minkowski vacuum in the Rindler basis reads, for each helicity sector,

$$|0\rangle^{(\lambda)}_M = \frac{1}{\cosh\theta_\Omega} \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \tanh^n\theta_\Omega \, |n_{\Omega,\lambda}\rangle_R \, |n_{\Omega,-\lambda}\rangle_L, \tag{20}$$

and the full vacuum is the product over all Ω and both helicities:

$$|0\rangle_M = \prod_{\Omega,\lambda} |0\rangle^{(\lambda)}_M. \tag{21}$$

Equation (20) makes explicit that the Minkowski vacuum is a sum over entangled helicity-anticorrelated pairs at each Rindler frequency. The bilocal source selects a single term from this sum at fixed Ω and fixed helicity pair $(\lambda, -\lambda) = (+1, -1)$, yielding the single-microstate

$$|\Psi_\Omega\rangle_M = |1_{\Omega,+1}\rangle_R \, |1_{\Omega,-1}\rangle_L + \mathcal{O}(\text{higher order}). \tag{22}$$

Wright's detection of helicity $+1$ and Lester's detection of helicity -1 are therefore perfectly anticorrelated: each measurement event yields one classical bit, and the two bits are the complement of one another.

The key structural result is that the helicity label λ is conserved under the Bogoliubov transformation: it enters equation (19) as a spectator index and exits unchanged on the Unruh operators $c_{\Omega,\lambda}$. Thermality, when it arises from coarse-graining over the ensemble of microstates (22), is therefore helicity-resolved: each helicity sector thermalises independently, and the anticorrelation between wedges is preserved at every level of the construction.

3.5 Summary

The passage from the scalar to the vector field construction introduces three structural improvements. First, the photon carrying $E = \hbar\omega$ and one quantum of action per cycle identifies the thrust quantum of Section 2 with a concrete physical object, closing the Landauer acquisition gap. Second, the double-null gauge condition, motivated by the pair of null directions defined by the emission event, treats both Rindler wedges symmetrically and exposes the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ swap symmetry as the organising principle of the construction. Third, the anticorrelated helicity structure, conserved through the Bogoliubov transformation, provides each observer with one classical bit whose values are perfectly complementary: the two bits together constitute the correlated classical record that, in the AS pp-wave picture of Section 5, is imprinted as geometric information onto the horizon.

4 Matter as Substrate: Ticks, Memory, and the Thrust Quantum

We show how information is encoded in matter and energy and is reflected in the horizon geometry. This requires a physical account of what it means for matter to *carry* information.

A massive particle accumulates phase along its worldline at a rate set by its rest energy. The Compton frequency relation $f = E/h$ assigns a natural frequency to any mass m, and Bremermann's computational limit [14] independently recovers the same rate $f = mc^2/h$ as the maximum clock rate, or Nyquist rate, of any physical system with that energy E. These two results agree because they are both expressions of the same underlying fact: a quantum of action $\hbar$ is the minimal unit of physical evolution, and mc^2/h is the rate at which a mass m consumes such quanta.

Each such quantum corresponds to one tick of the phase $e^{iS/\hbar}$ in the path integral, and classical trajectories emerge from the constructive interference of these ticks across paths. Paths separated by less than one tick of action, less than $\hbar$, contribute indistinguishably to the interference, so the trajectory is resolved only down to the scale set by $\hbar/E$: this is precisely the Heisenberg uncertainty at energy E, and coarser descriptions of the trajectory discard the sub-tick phase information that finer energy scales would reveal. This agrees notionally with the old quantum physics of Bohr and Sommerfeld and only picks up finer phase information at higher effective energy scales.

This gives matter a precise sense in which it is a *substrate for information*: it accumulates ticks, and each tick is a discrete unit of action, Lorentz-invariant and recorded in the particle's proper time. Matter is persistent memory in the operational sense that its history of ticks is physically encoded in its state and cannot be erased without an energy cost governed by Landauer's principle. The maximum rate of this memory is bounded by Bremermann.

A massless particle — the photon — has no rest frame, no proper time, and accumulates no action between emission and absorption. It does not tick. It therefore carries no persistent memory and cannot serve as a substrate. Its role in the present construction is precisely that of a pure information carrier. A single photon carries exactly two irreducible constituents, distinct in kind:

- **One quantum of action** $\hbar$: the physical transfer, deposited as energy $\hbar\omega$ into the detector, incrementing its Bremermann tick rate by $\Delta f = \hbar\omega/h$ for as long as the energy remains in the mass. This increment is the physical trace of the interaction in the detector's matter-memory.
- **One bit of polarisation**: the informational outcome, the classical record of which helicity — $\lambda = +1$ or $\lambda = -1$ — was absorbed. This bit persists in the detector's state for as long as the detector retains the record. Erasure of this bit carries a minimum energy cost governed by Landauer's principle, regardless of how the record was originally established. energy cost.

These are not the same thing in different guises. The $\hbar$ is what makes the event physical; the bit is what makes it meaningful to an observer. That a single photon carries exactly one of each is not a coincidence: it is why the photon is the natural minimal unit of the entire construction, the unique object that saturates both the action and the information count simultaneously. The energy deposited is $\Delta E = \hbar\omega$, saturating the Unruh–Landauer bound at the fundamental quantum level, as established in Section 3.

The horizon enters this picture not as a storage medium but as a boundary condition. It marks the surface at which the matter-memory on one side is causally disconnected from the matter-memory on the other. Horizon entropy, in this account, is not a property of the horizon surface itself but a count of the ticks that have been written into the matter on each side — bounded by Bremermann from above and by Landauer from below. The holographic appearance of this count, proportional to area rather than volume, is a consequence of the Unruh–Landauer and Bekenstein relations derived in Section 2 and does not require holography as an independent postulate.

This reframing has a direct consequence for the ER=EPR identification developed in the next subsection. The correlated measurement outcomes of Wright and Lester are not encoded in the horizon geometry in the first instance — they are encoded in the matter of

their respective detectors, each of which has absorbed one photon and accumulated one additional tick. The geometric correlations between the two wedges, realised as correlated AS pp-wave imprints in Section 5, are downstream of this matter-level encoding. The bridge, if it exists, is built from correlated ticks, not from the horizon itself.

4.1 Entanglement as Spatial Information: ER=EPR at the Microstate Level

Each measurement produces a polarisation outcome — H or V — at each wedge, perfectly anticorrelated between Lester and Wright. But consider a different question: not *what* was observed, but *where*. The question "who observed H?" has a binary answer: Lester (left wedge) or Wright (right wedge). This is a *spatial bit* — a bit that encodes not a polarisation state but a location in space.

Each measurement event has, as established in Section 4, exactly two irreducible constituents: one quantum of action $\hbar$ written irreversibly into the detector's matter-memory as a tick, and one bit of polarisation registered as a classical outcome. The entanglement between Wright and Lester is consumed in producing these two records — one tick and one bit at each wedge. What remains after measurement is not a remnant of the entanglement but its classical residue: the perfect anticorrelation between the two bits, and the correlated pair of ticks written into the matter on each side of the horizon. The spatial bit is precisely the polarisation bit of Section 4 now read as a location rather than a spin state: the same bit that records *what* was observed also records *where*, because in this construction the two wedges carry opposite helicities by design.

The information is carried by the matter of the detectors, not by the horizon. As established in Section 4, the horizon is a boundary that makes the left/right distinction sharp; it is the matter on each side that accumulates the ticks and holds the classical record. Wright's detector has absorbed one photon, gained one tick, and registered helicity $+1$. Lester's detector has absorbed one photon, gained one tick, and registered helicity -1. The two records are perfectly complementary by the anticorrelated structure of the bilocal source, and their complementarity is encoded in matter before it is reflected in geometry.

This reframing sharpens the ER=EPR identification. The two wedges are connected not by the horizon as an abstract geometric object but by the physical correlations between the energy-momentum impulses deposited in the matter on each side. In the AS pp-wave picture developed in Section 5, each such impulse produces a measurable longitudinal shift and transverse focusing of the horizon geometry. The correlated pair of impulses — one in each wedge, anticorrelated in helicity — produces correlated geometric deformations on the two sides of the horizon, and it is *this* geometric correlation, downstream of the matter-level encoding, that constitutes the Einstein–Rosen bridge at the level of a single microstate.

The spatial bit — the answer to "who observed H?" — is therefore not merely a record of which side the photon landed on. It is a label for which of the two correlated geometric deformations was realised, and the two labels together reconstruct the bridge. This is an operational realisation of ER=EPR at the level of individual microstates: the entanglement between Lester and Wright's outcomes is not a stand-in for the bridge but is physically instantiated in the pair of correlated ticks whose geometric imprint *is* the bridge. The bridge is built from matter, tick by tick.

4.2 The Zig-Zag Mechanism: Why Matter Ticks

The matter substrate argument of the preceding subsection established that massive particles tick at the Bremermann rate mc^2/h and that each tick is a quantum of action $\hbar$ accumulated in the path integral phase $e^{iS/\hbar}$. But it left open a prior question: *why* does

matter tick at all? The zig-zag construction of Penrose and Dirac supplies a concrete physical answer, and in doing so reveals that the bilocal microstate construction of Section 3 is not merely analogous to the origin of mass — it is structurally identical to it at the level of individual events.

The Dirac 4-Spinor as a Bilocal System

The Lorentz algebra decomposes as

$$\mathfrak{so}(3,1) \cong \mathfrak{su}(2) \times \mathfrak{su}(2), \tag{23}$$

where the two $\mathfrak{su}(2)$ factors correspond to the two helicities: the first is generated by boosts combined with counter-clockwise rotations, and the second by boosts combined with clockwise rotations [15]. A Dirac 4-spinor decomposes under this algebra into two Weyl 2-spinors of opposite helicity $\lambda = \pm\frac{1}{2}$ and equal and opposite momenta. Penrose [16] proposes a physical interpretation of this decomposition: the two 2-spinors are real physical objects, each moving instantaneously at the speed of light in opposite directions, interacting at regular intervals via the Higgs field at the De Broglie frequency.

The structural parallel with the bilocal construction is exact:

- The two Weyl 2-spinors, moving at c in opposite directions with opposite helicity, correspond to the two photons emitted by Paz into the left and right Rindler wedges.
- The Higgs field plays the role of Paz: it is the common mediator whose interaction produces the entangled pair and sets the interaction rate.
- Between Higgs interactions, each 2-spinor is massless and moves at c, carrying no persistent memory — pure information carriers, exactly as the photons in the bilocal construction.
- The Higgs interaction event itself is the measurement event: it deposits one quantum of action $\hbar$, flips the active helicity from $+\frac{1}{2}$ to $-\frac{1}{2}$ and back, and produces one tick of proper time.

Mass emerges from the regularity of these interactions: a particle is massive because it undergoes repeated Higgs interactions at the De Broglie frequency, and its mass is proportional to that frequency via $E = \hbar\omega$. The Bremermann tick rate mc^2/h is therefore not a coincidence or a heuristic — it is the Higgs interaction rate, the rate at which the zig-zag mechanism deposits quanta of action into the particle's proper time.

Mass as Accumulated Measurement History

Between Higgs interactions, the two 2-spinors are massless and moving at c in opposite null directions. Each spinor therefore has a local Rindler structure relative to the other: from the perspective of the right-moving spinor, the left-moving spinor is behind a causal horizon, and vice versa. The Higgs interaction is the event that collapses this local horizon and produces one tick — one unit of proper time — exactly as the photon absorption by Wright collapses the Rindler horizon and produces one tick in the bilocal construction.

This gives a precise sense in which mass is an accumulated measurement history. Each Higgs interaction is a measurement event in the sense of Section 4: it deposits one quantum of action $\hbar$ into the particle's matter-memory, permanently incrementing its tick rate by $\Delta f = \Delta E/h$. The particle's mass is the total accumulated record of all such interactions since its formation. Matter is not just the substrate for information — it *is* information, in the sense that its mass encodes the accumulated history of its Higgs interaction events.

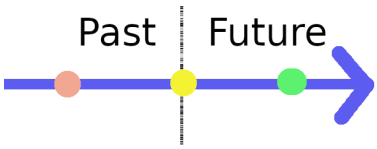

Figure 3: A 1-dimensional (proper) time line. The red, yellow, and green dots are 0-dimensional events, in the past, present and future respectively. A screen is pictured at the present.

Proper Time as a Foliation of Micro-Horizons

The series of Higgs interaction events along a particle's worldline is a one-dimensional foliation of the proper time line by discrete events, each of which is a micro-horizon separating the causal past from the causal future of that interaction, see FIgure 3. This is the one-dimensional analogue of the Rindler horizon separating left and right wedges in the bilocal construction, and it matches the holographic screen picture of Verlinde [2]: each screen is a surface at which information is registered and a tick of proper time is produced.

The zig-zag mechanism therefore provides a physical grounding for the matter substrate argument at the level of individual particles. The bilocal construction of Section 3 is the macroscopic version of the same structure: Paz plays the role of the Higgs field, the two photons play the role of the two Weyl spinors, and Wright and Lester's measurement events play the role of the Higgs interactions that produce ticks of proper time in the zig-zag picture. The difference in scale is large but the logical structure is identical.

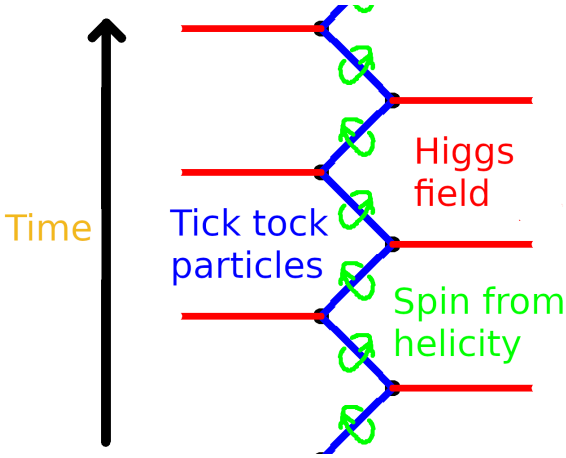

Figure 4: These figures were adapted from [16]. They show his interpretation of the Dirac equation and the Higgs mechanism for an electron.

5 Gravitational Imprint: the pp-Wave Realisation

Each measurement event in the bilocal construction involves a photon transferring energy and momentum to an accelerated detector. We now model the gravitational imprint of this transfer by identifying each photon with an Aichelburg–Sexl (AS) pp-wave solution in general relativity [17]. The AS geometry is an exact solution describing the gravitational field of an ultrarelativistic point mass, and provides the natural geometric language for a single-photon microstate.

5.1 The AS pp-Wave and Its Effects

Let $u = t - z$ and $v = t + z$, where the photon propagates along the null plane $u = 0$, z is the longitudinal direction, and (x, y) are transverse coordinates. Test particles at fixed transverse positions (x, y) experience two effects as the shock front crosses $u = 0$:

1. **Longitudinal shift.** The v coordinate is displaced by

$$\Delta v \propto -\ln r^2, \qquad r^2 = x^2 + y^2. \tag{24}$$

   This shift is lightlike: no proper time elapses for a particle crossing the shock, but it is displaced along the null direction. Near the axis ($r \to 0$) the shift diverges, encoding the concentration of energy along the photon's trajectory.

2. **Transverse focusing.** The gradient of the longitudinal shift produces a transverse velocity

$$\Delta \mathbf{v}_\perp \propto \nabla \ln r \propto \frac{1}{r}, \tag{25}$$

   directed toward the axis. Test particles are pulled toward the centre of the wave, regardless of their initial transverse separation.

5.2 The Longitudinal Shift Makes Space

The longitudinal shift deserves closer attention, because it carries a meaning beyond a mere coordinate displacement. The photon emitted by Paz propagates along the null direction; as it crosses the Rindler horizon, the AS shift displaces the future light cone of every test particle it passes. For the photon traveling into the right wedge, the shift pushes the right wedge's geometry in the $+v$ direction; for the entangled partner traveling into the left wedge, the shift pushes the left wedge in the $-v$ direction. The two wedges are displaced *away from each other* along the longitudinal null direction.

This is not merely a kinematic effect. The transverse plane of the pp-wave is identified with horizon area elements $dA = dx\,dy$, and the longitudinal shift creates a new null interval between the two wedges — a region of spacetime that did not exist, in the sense of being causally accessible, before the photon passed. The bit of spatial information encoded in the left/right measurement outcome — "who observed H?" — refers to precisely this separation. The measurement event does not merely *record* a spatial distinction; through the gravitational backreaction of the photon, it *creates* the spatial separation that the bit describes.

Put differently: the same physical event — a photon crossing a horizon — simultaneously encodes a classical bit and, via the AS longitudinal shift, generates the spatial structure that bit refers to. Space is not a pre-existing backdrop onto which information is written; it is produced, increment by increment, by the gravitational imprint of each measurement event. This is the microstate-level content of emergent space: each detection event contributes both an entropy increment and a spatial increment, and the two are the same thing described in different languages.

5.3 Horizon Entropy from Individual Microstates

Each detection event contributes a discrete entropy increment via the Bekenstein–Hawking relation derived in Section 2:

$$\Delta S = \frac{\Delta A}{4\ell_P^2}, \qquad \ell_P^2 = \frac{\hbar G}{c^3}, \tag{26}$$

where ΔA is the area element imprinted on the horizon by the transverse focusing of the pp-wave. Horizon entropy is therefore not a bulk thermodynamic quantity assigned to the horizon as a whole, but a sum of discrete, calculable contributions from individual

measurement-induced interactions. The transverse focusing and the longitudinal shift are two aspects of the same microstate: focusing encodes the entropy increment in the area; the longitudinal shift encodes the spatial increment in the geometry.

5.4 Coarse-Graining and the Emergence of Thermality

In a steady-state scenario, Paz continuously emits entangled pairs, and Lester and Wright continuously detect them. Each detection is an AS pp-wave microstate with a definite, non-thermal description in the global Minkowski frame: a specific photon energy, a specific transverse position, a specific longitudinal shift. Coarse-graining over this ensemble recovers the Unruh thermal spectrum at temperature $T = a/2\pi$, consistent with the vacuum decomposition of equation (**??**). The thermodynamic description of the horizon emerges from this averaging; it is not a feature of the individual microstates.

This completes the microstate programme. Each entropy increment in the Bekenstein–Hawking area law corresponds to a single AS pp-wave interaction. Each pp-wave interaction corresponds to a single measurement event in the bilocal construction. Each measurement event both encodes a spatial bit and generates the spatial separation that bit refers to. The gravitational, thermodynamic, information-theoretic, and geometric descriptions of the horizon are unified at the level of individual microstates, and thermality, entropy, and space itself emerge together from the coarse-grained aggregate of these events.

6 Connecting Microstates to Emergent Geometry

The preceding sections established three key loci where the geometry responds to information-processing events:

1. **Paz in the past:** the bilocal source injects energy and angular momentum, which can be associated with a Schwarzschild-like mass m_P encoding the initial acceleration of the detectors.
2. **Photon crossing the horizon:** each emitted photon carries energy $E = \hbar\omega$ and a helicity bit, producing an Aichelburg–Sexl pp-wave whose longitudinal shift generates a new null separation between wedges and whose transverse focusing increments the horizon area.
3. **Wright/Lester detectors:** absorption of the photon imprints energy and one classical bit into the matter-memory of each detector, producing local Schwarzschild-like responses m_W, m_L and marking the accumulation of *ticks*.

Each of these loci has its own emergent time, defined operationally by the sequence of discrete *ticks* accumulated in the proper time of matter carrying information. For the photon itself, no proper time elapses; it carries a *pure transfer* of energy and one classical bit. The photon's passage between emission and detection mediates correlations that are encoded as entanglement between the ticks of Wright and Lester, and as longitudinal shifts of the horizon in the pp-wave picture.

The Raychaudhuri equation applied to each infinitesimal horizon element ensures that the transverse focusing $\Delta\theta_\perp$ matches the area increment ΔA associated with a single microstate. This realizes the Bekenstein–Hawking relation at the level of individual detection events, making Jacobson's thermodynamic argument manifest at the microstate scale.

The longitudinal shifts, meanwhile, generate the *spatial separation* that the entanglement between detectors refers to: space is created incrementally as a direct consequence of energy-momentum transfer and measurement. In this sense, ER=EPR is instantiated

physically: the Einstein–Rosen bridge between the left and right wedges is not postulated, but emerges as the cumulative geometric imprint of paired ticks and photons, each producing correlated pp-wave distortions.

The sequence

$$\text{Paz source} \xrightarrow{\text{photon emission}} \text{pp-wave horizon shift} \xrightarrow{\text{detector absorption}} \text{matter ticks} \tag{27}$$

provides a concrete operational dictionary linking energy, information, and geometry. Each step is reversible in principle except for the Landauer cost encoded in the matter-memory, and coarse-graining over many such events recovers the familiar thermal horizon description.

In this framework, *space, time, and entropy emerge simultaneously from discrete microphysical events.* Proper time flows in the detectors via tick accumulation, spatial separation arises from longitudinal pp-wave shifts, and horizon area encodes entropy through transverse focusing. Each photon acts as a bridge between these emergent structures, unifying the information-theoretic, gravitational, and thermodynamic perspectives into a single microstate-level picture.

6.1 Horizon Area Change from a Single AS Photon

The connection between energy flux across a null surface and horizon area change follows directly from Jacobson's derivation of the Einstein equations from horizon thermodynamics [1]. In his framework, for a null congruence generating a local Rindler horizon, the Raychaudhuri equation

$$\frac{d\theta}{du} = -\frac{1}{2}\theta^2 - \sigma_{\mu\nu}\sigma^{\mu\nu} - 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu}k^\mu k^\nu \tag{28}$$

relates the expansion θ to the energy-momentum flux $T_{\mu\nu}$ along null generators k^μ. Integrating over the horizon patch and assuming linearised focusing gives

$$\delta A = 8\pi G \int T_{\mu\nu}k^\mu k^\nu \, du \, d^2x_\perp, \tag{29}$$

which in Jacobson's derivation leads to the Einstein equation as a thermodynamic consistency condition.

The formal use of the Raychaudhuri equation and the identification of the area change δA with the integrated null energy flux is exactly as in Jacobson. The logic that links energy flux to an infinitesimal area change along a null surface is unchanged.

In our microstate construction, the energy flux $T_{\mu\nu}$ is *discrete*: it corresponds to a single AS photon carrying energy $\Delta E = \hbar\omega$. The area change becomes

$$\Delta A = 8\pi G \, \Delta E, \tag{30}$$

applied to the transverse patch intersected by the photon. Unlike the smooth, coarse-grained description in Jacobson, each microstate produces a calculable, individual contribution to the horizon area. Moreover, the longitudinal shift of the AS pp-wave simultaneously generates the *spatial separation* that encodes the spatial bit in the ER=EPR construction. This demonstrates concretely that each detection event both writes a bit into the matter-memory of the detectors and creates the corresponding geometric imprint, unifying information, energy, and space at the level of a single microstate.

Applying the Bekenstein–Hawking relation gives the entropy increment:

$$\Delta S = \frac{\Delta A}{4\ell_P^2}, \qquad \ell_P^2 = \frac{\hbar G}{c^3}. \tag{31}$$

Thus, the photon produces a discrete entropy contribution and a corresponding spatial increment: the horizon thermodynamics emerges microstate by microstate, rather than as a smooth, macroscopic average.

This is a concrete, microphysical realization of Jacobson's ideas. Whereas Jacobson used horizon thermodynamics as a consistency argument to recover Einstein's equations, here each quantum of energy and information — each photon — produces a tangible change in horizon area and geometry, and the same event encodes information and space simultaneously. It gives a bridge from microscopic events (photon detection, tick accumulation, polarisation bits) to emergent spacetime, providing a detailed operational picture of ER=EPR and the origin of horizon entropy in a single, physically transparent step.

6.2 Planck-Unit Horizon Area from a Single Photon

Each AS pp-wave microstate corresponds to a single photon transferring energy $\Delta E = \hbar\omega$ to an accelerated detector. From the Bekenstein–Hawking relation, the associated horizon area increment is

$$\Delta A = 4\ell_P^2\,\Delta S = 4\ell_P^2 \frac{\Delta E}{T_{\text{eff}}}, \tag{32}$$

where T_{eff} is the effective Unruh temperature seen by the detector.

In Planck units, this gives

$$\Delta A \sim 8\pi\ell_P^2 \frac{\hbar\omega}{m_P c^2}, \tag{33}$$

where $m_P = \sqrt{\hbar c/G}$ is the Planck mass. Each photon therefore imprints a discrete patch of area on the horizon, measured in multiples of ℓ_P^2, linking the minimal quantum of action $\hbar$ directly to the minimal increment of horizon area.

This is a special case of the standard Bekenstein–Hawking law: instead of considering a macroscopic black hole or a coarse-grained ensemble, we see that a single actionable quantum (a photon) produces a calculable Planck-scale increment. It makes the horizon *operationally granular*, with each Planck-area patch corresponding to a single measurement event, a single Landauer tick, and a single spatial bit. This establishes a concrete bridge between quantum information, energy transfer, and emergent geometry.

7 Appendix: Consistency of the Double-Null Gauge Condition

We verify that the double-null gauge condition $A_+ = A_- = 0$ is consistent with Maxwell's equations and leaves exactly two physical degrees of freedom.

Coordinates and Notation

In double-null coordinates (x^+, x^-, x^1, x^2) the Minkowski metric reads

$$ds^2 = -2\,dx^+\,dx^- + (dx^1)^2 + (dx^2)^2, \tag{34}$$

so that $\partial_+ = \partial/\partial x^+$, $\partial_- = \partial/\partial x^-$, and the d'Alembertian is

$$\Box = -2\partial_+\partial_- + \partial_i\partial^i, \qquad i = 1, 2. \tag{35}$$

The gauge field has components $A_\mu = (A_+, A_-, A_1, A_2)$ and transforms as

$$A_\mu \to A_\mu + \partial_\mu \Lambda \tag{36}$$

under a gauge transformation with parameter $\Lambda(x^+, x^-, x^1, x^2)$.

Imposing the Gauge Conditions in Stages

The single gauge parameter Λ is a function of all four coordinates. We use it in three stages, each consuming a different functional dependence.

Stage 1: $A_+ = 0$. Requiring $A_+ + \partial_+\Lambda = 0$ determines Λ as a function of x^+:

$$\Lambda(x^+, x^-, x^i) = -\int^{x^+} A_+(s, x^-, x^i)\, ds + \Lambda_0(x^-, x^i), \tag{37}$$

where $\Lambda_0(x^-, x^i)$ is an arbitrary residual function independent of x^+.

Stage 2: $A_- = 0$. Under the residual freedom $\Lambda_0(x^-, x^i)$, the A_- component transforms as $A_- \to A_- + \partial_-\Lambda_0$. Setting this to zero determines Λ_0 as a function of x^-:

$$\Lambda_0(x^-, x^i) = -\int^{x^-} A_-(s, x^i)\, ds + \Lambda_1(x^i), \tag{38}$$

where $\Lambda_1(x^i)$ is a residual function of the transverse coordinates only.

Stage 3: Transverse Coulomb condition $\partial^i A_i = 0$. Under the remaining freedom $\Lambda_1(x^i)$, the transverse components transform as $A_i \to A_i + \partial_i\Lambda_1$. Imposing $\partial^i A_i = 0$ requires

$$\nabla_\perp^2 \Lambda_1 = -\partial^i A_i, \tag{39}$$

which is a Poisson equation in the transverse plane with a unique solution (up to harmonic functions, fixed by boundary conditions). This exhausts the gauge freedom entirely.

The three conditions have consumed the full gauge parameter Λ in stages, with no over-determination: each stage uses a strictly different functional dependence of Λ.

Physical Degrees of Freedom

After imposing $A_+ = A_- = 0$ and $\partial^i A_i = 0$, the remaining components are A_1 and A_2 subject to one differential constraint $\partial^i A_i = 0$. In momentum space this reads $k^i A_i = 0$.

For our specific construction, the photons propagate in the $\pm z$ direction, so their wave-vectors are purely null: $k_\perp^i = 0$ for $i = 1, 2$. The transverse Coulomb condition $k^i A_i = 0$ is therefore trivially satisfied for any A_1, A_2, and both transverse components are independent. The two circular polarisation vectors

$$\epsilon^i_{(+1)} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix}1\\ i\end{pmatrix}, \qquad \epsilon^i_{(-1)} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}\begin{pmatrix}1\\ -i\end{pmatrix} \tag{40}$$

are the two independent physical degrees of freedom, corresponding to helicity $\lambda = \pm 1$. This is the correct count for a massless spin-1 field in four dimensions.

Consistency with Maxwell's Equations

With $A_+ = A_- = 0$ and $\partial^i A_i = 0$, the non-zero field strength components are

$$F_{+i} = \partial_+ A_i, \qquad F_{-i} = \partial_- A_i, \qquad F_{ij} = \partial_i A_j - \partial_j A_i, \qquad F_{+-} = 0. \tag{41}$$

Maxwell's equations $\partial^\mu F_{\mu\nu} = J_\nu$ decompose as follows.

Transverse components $\nu = i$:

$$-2\partial_+\partial_- A_i + \partial^j(\partial_j A_i - \partial_i A_j) = J_i. \tag{42}$$

Using $\partial^i A_i = 0$, the second term simplifies to $\partial^j\partial_j A_i$, giving the standard wave equation

$$\boxed{\Box A_i = J_i.} \tag{43}$$

Null components $\nu = \pm$:

$$-\partial^i \partial_\pm A_i = J_\pm. \tag{44}$$

These are constraint equations relating the null source components to the transverse field. For our bilocal source, which is purely transverse, $J_+ = J_- = 0$, and the constraints reduce to

$$\partial^i \partial_\pm A_i = 0. \tag{45}$$

Differentiating the transverse Coulomb condition $\partial^i A_i = 0$ with respect to $x^\pm$ gives $\partial^i(\partial_\pm A_i) = 0$, so these constraints are automatically satisfied. ✓

Summary

The double-null gauge condition $A_+ = A_- = 0$ supplemented by the transverse Coulomb condition $\partial^i A_i = 0$:

1. uses the gauge freedom of Λ completely and without over-determination, via a three-stage procedure consuming the x^+-, x^--, and x^i-dependent parts of Λ in sequence;
2. leaves exactly two physical degrees of freedom, the helicity eigenstates $\lambda = \pm 1$, consistent with the known count for a massless spin-1 field;
3. reduces Maxwell's equations to the standard transverse wave equation $\Box A_i = J_i$, with the null constraint equations automatically satisfied for a purely transverse source.

The gauge is therefore internally consistent and does not over-constrain the physical degrees of freedom. The $\mathbb{Z}_2$ wedge-swap symmetry is preserved throughout: conditions on A_+ and A_- are imposed symmetrically, and neither null direction is privileged over the other.

8 Emergent Spacetime from Ticks and Correlations

The bilocal construction of Section 3 and the matter substrate argument of Section 4 together suggest a picture in which spacetime is not a background arena but an emergent property of matter and its correlations. We develop this picture here, drawing on [**?**]. The central claim is that time and space are distinct emergent phenomena with distinct physical origins: time emerges from the tick count of a single massive particle, and space emerges from the phase difference between tick counts of two or more correlated systems. Together they give emergent spacetime without assuming a geometric background.

8.1 Emergent Time: Ticks as Proper Time

A massive particle at rest oscillates at the Compton frequency

$$\omega = \frac{mc^2}{\hbar}, \tag{46}$$

and accumulates phase $e^{i\omega t}$ along its worldline. We define the *tick set* of the particle between proper times τ_1 and τ_2 as the set of zero crossings of this phase:

$$\mathcal{T}_{\tau_1,\tau_2} = \left\{ \tau \in [\tau_1, \tau_2] : \tau \in \frac{2\pi}{\omega}\mathbb{Z} \right\}. \tag{47}$$

The cardinality $|\mathcal{T}|$ is the tick count between the two events. This is a Lorentz-invariant quantity: it is the number of times the particle's phase completes a full cycle, which

is an intrinsic property of the worldline independent of any external observer. Proper time is the continuum limit of tick counting, and the Compton frequency $\omega = mc^2/\hbar$ is simultaneously the Bremermann rate — the maximum tick rate for a system of energy mc^2 — and the Nyquist rate for the matter channel.

The tick count admits a natural Hilbert space description. We define

$$\mathcal{H}(T) = \mathrm{Span}\left\{|0\rangle, |1\rangle, |2\rangle, \ldots\right\}, \tag{48}$$

where $|n\rangle$ represents an observable tick count of n. The position operator $\hat{N}|n\rangle = n|n\rangle$ is the tick number operator, and its conjugate under the discrete Fourier transform is the frequency operator on the circle group S^1, with the Nyquist frequency as the maximum. Wavefunctions $\psi(n)$ on $\mathcal{H}(T)$ describe superpositions of tick counts, and classical proper time emerges from the expectation value $\langle \hat{N} \rangle$ in states sharply peaked around large n.

8.2 Emergent Space: Phase Difference as Spatial Separation

A single particle's tick count gives time but not space. Space requires at least two correlated systems. Consider a particle in quantum superposition traversing two spatially separated paths, with tick counts n_1 and n_2 accumulated along each path. The interference pattern produced when the paths recombine is labelled by the fringe index

$$k = n_1 - n_2, \tag{49}$$

which is the tick difference between the two paths. Each value of k corresponds to a distinct fringe of constructive interference, and the spatial separation between fringes is set by the Compton wavelength $\lambda = h/mc$. The fringe index k is therefore a spatial quantum number: it labels a position in space relative to the interference pattern, and space emerges as the eigenvalue spectrum of the operator

$$\hat{K} = \hat{N}_1 - \hat{N}_2 \tag{50}$$

acting on the joint Hilbert space

$$\mathcal{H}(T_1, T_2) = \mathcal{H}(T_1) \otimes \mathcal{H}(T_2) = \bigoplus_{k \in \mathbb{Z}} \mathcal{P}_k, \tag{51}$$

where $\mathcal{P}_k = \mathrm{Span}\{|i\rangle \otimes |j\rangle : i - j = k\}$ is the eigenspace of $\hat{K}$ with eigenvalue k [**?**]. The spatial position is the eigenvalue of $\hat{K}$; it is not assumed but derived from the relative tick count.

The structure of $\mathcal{H}(T_1, T_2)$ makes an important point: we do not symmetrise the tensor product, because $|i\rangle \otimes |j\rangle$ and $|j\rangle \otimes |i\rangle$ represent physically distinct configurations — the particle went through path 1 first in one case and path 2 first in the other. The two tick counts are distinguishable, and space inherits that distinguishability.

Curvature enters naturally in this language. In flat spacetime, the tick counts $n_1, \ldots, n_m$ for m paths are linearly related: any n_i is a linear combination of n_1 and n_2 [**?**]. In curved spacetime, the geodesic paths between points acquire different lengths, and the tick counts are nonlinearly related in precisely the way that encodes the curvature. Gravity, in this picture, is the statement that the tick relationships between correlated matter systems are nonlinear — and the Einstein equations are the consistency conditions on those nonlinear relationships.

8.3 Summary

Time and space emerge from matter in distinct but complementary ways:

- **Emergent time**: the tick count $|\mathcal{T}|$ along a single worldline, with the Compton frequency as the Nyquist rate and proper time as the continuum limit.
- **Emergent space**: the tick difference $k = n_1 - n_2$ between two correlated systems, with the Compton wavelength setting the fringe scale and spatial position as the eigenvalue of $\hat{K}$.
- **Emergent curvature**: the nonlinearity of tick relationships across multiple paths, encoding the deviation from flat spacetime.

In the bilocal construction, the photon from Paz is the physical event that correlates Wright's and Lester's tick counts, establishing the spatial separation between the wedges as a classical fact. The horizon is the zero eigenspace of $\hat{K}$. Gravity is the mechanics of correlated tick counts. Spacetime is what matter does.

9 Unifying the Saturation Conditions

The heuristics of Section 2 and the tick picture of Section 8 each arrive independently at a saturation condition that singles out the horizon. We now show these are the same condition expressed in three complementary languages: thermodynamic, energetic, and information-theoretic.

9.1 The Energy Ratio α

For a physical system of mass m with characteristic radius R, define

$$\alpha \equiv \frac{E_\hbar}{E_G} = \frac{mc^2}{Gm^2/R} = \frac{c^2 R}{Gm}, \tag{52}$$

where $E_\hbar = mc^2$ is the rest energy, which sets the Bremermann tick rate $f = mc^2/h$, and $E_G = Gm^2/R$ is the gravitational self-energy of the configuration. The ratio α is dimensionless and measures how far the system is from the regime in which quantum and gravitational energy scales coincide.

Physical configurations accessible to an external observer satisfy $E_\hbar \geq E_G$, equivalently $\alpha \geq 1$: a system with $E_G > E_\hbar$ would lie within its own Schwarzschild radius and be causally inaccessible. Setting $\alpha = 1$ gives

$$R_{\alpha=1} = \frac{Gm}{c^2} \sim r_s = \frac{2Gm}{c^2}, \tag{53}$$

which is the Schwarzschild radius up to an $O(1)$ numerical factor reflecting the conventional choice of E_G. As with the factor of 2 absorbed into the interaction time $\Delta t = 2r/c$ in Section 2, this factor is fixed by requiring consistency with Newtonian gravity at the horizon scale; it does not affect the parametric identification.

9.2 Three Languages for the Same Condition

The condition $\alpha = 1$ is the same physical statement as the Landauer saturation condition of Section 2 and the tick-accumulation limit of Section 8. The three descriptions are:

Thermodynamic language. The Unruh–Landauer bound and the Bekenstein–Hawking area law saturate simultaneously when $a = c^2/R$. Using the conversion between Boltzmann entropy and Shannon bits,

$$S_B = k_B \ln 2 \cdot H, \tag{54}$$

the Unruh–Landauer bound (3) expressed in bits reads

$$\Delta E \geq \frac{\hbar a \ln 2}{2\pi c} \Delta H, \tag{55}$$

and saturates when $a = c^2/R \sim c^4/Gm$, i.e. at $R \sim Gm/c^2 \sim r_s$. The horizon is the unique locus where the minimum energy cost per bit acquired equals the maximum information content per unit area.

Energetic language. The ratio $\alpha = E_\hbar/E_G$ reaches its minimum value of unity at $R \sim r_s$. At this point the quantum energy available for tick accumulation exactly equals the gravitational self-energy: no further information can be written into the system by an external observer without the system collapsing. The inequality $\alpha \geq 1$ is the energetic form of the holographic bound — the information capacity of the system, set by $E_\hbar$, must be at least as large as the gravitational cost of sustaining the configuration, set by E_G.

Tick language. The Bremermann rate $f = mc^2/h$ sets the maximum rate at which matter accumulates quanta of action $\hbar$ as ticks. The gravitational self-energy $E_G \sim Gm^2/R$ sets the scale at which ticks in one region of matter are gravitationally correlated with ticks in another. At $\alpha = 1$ these two rates coincide: the intrinsic tick rate of the matter equals the rate at which the gravitational field can propagate correlations between ticks. The horizon is therefore the surface at which the local information processing rate and the global gravitational coupling are in balance.

9.3 The Horizon as a Fixed Point

These three descriptions converge on a single structural statement: *the horizon is the fixed point of the map between quantum information content and gravitational geometry.* Away from the horizon, $\alpha > 1$: the matter has more information capacity than the gravitational field accounts for, and space is created tick by tick as described in Section 5. At the horizon, $\alpha = 1$: the two accounts balance exactly, the Landauer bound (55) saturates, the Bekenstein–Hawking area law is tight, and the tick-to-gravitational-energy ratio reaches its minimum.

The α ratio makes the thermodynamic statement of Section 2 precise in energetic terms, and the tick language makes it precise in terms of the physical process — matter accumulating correlated quanta of action — that underlies both. All three are expressions of the same fixed-point condition: the horizon is not where thermodynamics happens to work out, but the unique locus where the minimum cost of information acquisition, the maximum information content of the region, and the balance between quantum and gravitational energy scales are simultaneously achieved.

10 Conclusion

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